Introduction to Research, Scholarly and Creative Activity Competency

Research, scholarly and creative activity is one of the three competencies in the Honors Program. By completing the program, students will have demonstrated the ability to exhibit information literacy skills; synthesize and integrate ideas; produce original research, scholarship, or creative works; and contribute to knowledge.

What is Research, Scholarship and Creative Activity?

When we think of research, we often visualize a scientist in a laboratory. However, research is much broader than conducting experiments. Booth, Colomb, and Williams (2008) explain, "we do research whenever we gather information to answer a question that solves a problem" (p.10). For example, when selecting a college to attend students must confront the problem of paying for tuition. To address this problem a student may ask, "Which schools in Minnesota offer affordable tuition?" The student must then gather information to answer that question. At the most basic level, this is research.

However, in a scholarly setting our approach to asking and answering questions becomes more developed. Plano, Clark, and Cresswell (2010) define research as "a process of steps used to collect and analyze information in order to increase our understanding of a topic or issue" (p. 4). Scholarly research is about systematically seeking informed answers to questions. Sometimes we answer questions by investigating knowledge others have generated, other times we are responsible for making these discoveries through our own careful inquires. Regardless of one's approach, an ethical scholar must be able to critically evaluate and synthesize information and know the best practices of extending knowledge within one's own discipline.

What research have you already conducted in your personal life? Explain how your example meets the definition of research.

I have not done a lot of lab or studying research so far in my life. The only thing that I have has been gathering information to help solve a problem in some way which is what is defined here. What I can think of that meets this requirements is when I have studied for any classes for homework, or to gain information on a topic I am interested in. So according to the requirements for scholarly reasearch, a lot of learning, almost all I have done in schooling, is research. Specifically to my personal life I am very interested in planes as well as business so I have learned about planes, as well as learning about stocks and building a business

What research have you already conducted in your academic life? Explain how your example meets the definition of research.

In my academic life I have conducted research was specifically I know of is in Physics this year so far. I have done a lot of studying because this class is new to me to acquire new information on a given topic.

What is a Research Paradigm?

A paradigm is a perspective that guides one's thinking. Therefore, a research paradigm is a set of assumptions that guide the inquiry process. The two most common paradigms guiding research are the scientific paradigm and the naturalistic paradigm. The scientific paradigm takes an objective view of the world and looks at concrete and observable cause and effect relationships. The naturalistic paradigm takes a more subjective view of the world and recognizes the existence of multiple explanations and realities. Different academic disciplines tend to prefer one paradigm over the other. Those who study the natural sciences may align themselves with the scientific paradigm whereas those in the humanities may adhere to the naturalistic paradigm.

Within this competency area students may also choose to engage in creative achievement rather than traditional research. Creative work can be considered a form of scholarship. The Broadcast Educator's Association

maintains,

> "Creative work is intellectually demanding in similar ways to that of traditional research, including the collection, analysis, and synthesis of content. The creative process also involves discovery in the development of effective aural and visual forms and provides integration as these forms are united with content to create the final work."

One perspective is not better than the other, they are just different ways of seeing the world. Many people are drawn to a specific research paradigm or creative practice based on their personal world view. This perspective influences the kinds of research questions one asks as well as the methods one may use to answer those questions.

Which of the research paradigms mentioned above appeals to you the most? Explain your answer.
I like the naturalistic paradigm mentioned above the most. I think that the observational aspect of that view makes more sense to me and seeing connections within nature rather than creating only one concrete answer.

The links below showcase examples of research projects completed by previous Honors students. These projects highlight the various perspectives and approaches to scholarship and creative achievement.
Social Science Qualitative Interviewing: The Politics of Black Women's Hair
Art Criticism: Satirical Imagery of the Ramesside Period: A Socio-historical Narrative
Creative Non-Fiction Writing: Small Town Changes, excerpt
Creative Project with Sculpture and Dance: Performance Sculpture—An Exploratory Collaboration between Sculpture and Dance
Experimental Biological Science: Protective Effect of Beta-Sitosterol against Ethanol Toxemia
Literary Criticism using Textual Analysis: Leopoldo Lugones and Jorge Luis Borges on Science: The Garden of Forking Opinions
Policy Analysis and Criticism: Social Welfare Policy Reform Since the 1990s: Comparison of the United Kingdom and the Czech Republic

Open a few of the links above and skim the documents to learn more about the research that was conducted. Which of these projects do you find most interesting either in terms of content, research paradigm, or research methods?
I enjoyed reading the Effect of Beta-Sitosterol against Ethanol Toxemia. Although I appeal more to the naturalistic perspective, I find learning more about the scientific paradigm the most because it is entertaining to me. I thought the content of this piece was very fascinating. Learning the effect of these drugs on mice allows us to understand the effect that it can have on humans is super interesting to me.

What is a scholarly community?
A community is a group of individuals who share common interests, goals, or characteristics. As an honors student you are a member of the honors community, which is a group of individual students committed to the shared goal of developing in the competency areas of leadership, research, and intercultural engagement. Part of your competency development will include finding your place in a scholarly community within your field of study. Being the member of a scholarly community comes with expectations and responsibilities. You will be expected to contribute to the knowledge and practice of your discipline both through producing and presenting research and/or creative work. As you establish your place in a scholarly community you will learn the norms

and ethical research responsibilities of that community.
What are potential ethical concerns that might emerge in your scholarly community of interest?
Everyone in the community has similar if not the same points of views which can lead to very bias opinions on given topics, leading the group to do things that are wrong, because no one sees it as wrong.

Growing in the Competency

Now that you have a sense of what research, scholarly, and creative activity might mean and your future role as part of a scholarly community, let's examine how the honors program seeks to help you grow in this area. We focus on four components: information literacy, information synthesis, original research, and dissemination of results.

Information Literacy

The information literacy area focuses on developing your ability to gather already existing information to incorporate into your knowledge base and ultimately support a specific research goal. Information literacy requires that information be critically evaluated based on quality and that information be used ethically. To begin, we encourage you to access information effectively, efficiently, and critically; demonstrate that you understand how to use this information ethically; and demonstrate how to incorporate the evaluated information into your personal knowledge base. This skill is the foundation to being an informed scholar and citizen. Next, we will encourage you go a step further and incorporate your new knowledge to help you accomplish a specific research goal. For example, the completion of a literature review that grounds a research paper would meet this objective. In a world where information is easily accessible and often unreliable, knowing how to evaluate, process, and effectively use information is vitally important.

Think of a project for which you've gathered information previously. How did you search for sources? How did you identify which sources were credible? What would have been the consequences had you used misinformation?

We have had to do a lot of research in my AP Language and Composition class in 11th grade. With this we could only use credible sources, which we had to find and confirm were credible via credible government website checkers, or going through a series of steps to confirm the website was credible. If mis information was used the information we displayed could have mis informed more people. It could have also lead to us being mis informed ourselves and saying incorrect things making ourselves look uneducated.

Information Synthesis

The information synthesis area focuses more specifically on how one processes a variety of information to help build a specific argument or thesis. When engaging in research, scholarly, and creative activity you will find opposing views and conflicting evidence. The area of information synthesis helps you develop skills to evaluate and synthesize these different perspectives. Initially, you will learn to organize others' ideas. For example, many of the assignments you complete in entry level courses will ask you to read multiple authors discussing a similar topic and then write an organized reflection explaining your reaction to these readings. Next, we encourage you to think more deeply about diverse perspectives on a topic and how to synthesize that information into one coherent argument. Finally, you will be asked to articulate how a paper or project you have completed that engages in strong information synthesis contributes to new knowledge and your understanding of the research process as a whole. This final stage will involve critical reflection *after* you have completed the project to show you understand *how* you built your arguments.

Think of a time when you've had to make an argument. This could be for a formal academic paper or just in conversation with another person. How did you provide evidence to support your argument? How did you

combine different perspectives as part of your argument? Where do you see this skill utilized – either effectively or ineffectively – in society?
Whenever I would have had to provide evidence, I often would make sure to use something like a fact or website to back up my information. I also found a technique that I learned in 7th grade of accepting the others fact, but then rebutting it with a stronger and more emotional fact of some sort, which also helped me display other perspectives than my own so they could see I was open minded. I think this is often used effectively in society, especially in the recent debates, and when the opponent is too closed minded they often make themselves look like a fool.

Original Research
The original research area requires students to conduct their own independent research, scholarly, or creative project. What this will look like depends on your field of study. Because of the advanced skills required to complete this work, much of your growth in this area will occur later in your academic career. Students will identify and then develop a research question or creative proposal that extends the knowledge or practice in their discipline. The next step is to conduct primary research or complete the creative project. The final stage in meeting this competency involves students articulating how their project extends knowledge or practice in their discipline. Therefore, students not only complete a project, but can also explain why their work matters beyond their own personal learning.
The Undergraduate Research Center is an excellent campus resource to help you begin to conduct your own original research. There are several resources available on their website for you to use. Visit http://www.mnsu.edu/urc/ for more information. Better yet, when visiting the Honors Lounge, stop by and introduce yourself to the Undergraduate Research Center staff.

What are some big questions that you have about the world that you might be interested in exploring? How do you think you might start answering your big questions?
A lot of my big questions I have on the world are more conspiracy theories that could be impossible to answer. More questions that are more researchable that I have are about what the future will look like. I am sure I could dive into things about AI and more modern companies to understand a little more about possibilities.

Dissemination of Results
The dissemination of results is the culmination of your growth in this competency. The first step is to identify an appropriate venue through which to disseminate your work. Once a venue has been identified, students work toward preparing and submitting an abstract or proposal for acceptance to present at the selected venue and then actually present this work. Many students meet this expectation by presenting at an undergraduate research conference or by showing their creative work during a local public performance or exhibition. Although not required, some students move to publication of their work or creative achievement in a peer-reviewed venue. Again, the Undergraduate Research Center can help you disseminate your research. This link provides information about several local and regional conferences MNSU students can attend: http://www.mnsu.edu/urc/shareproject.html

Think back to a time when you presented something to other people. What went well? What didn't go well? What did you learn from the experience?
Something that I presented to other people was a debate about money and happiness. This is an example of a debate I lost so I thought it would be nice to bring up. Something that went well was the other side had a lot of facts, and for me I just had a lot of feeling based facts and opinions. I learned from this that if you want to gain

someone's interest you need to satisfy their ethos pathos and logos, and not just heavily appeal one area.

So What?

Why is research, scholarly and creative activity such a big deal? Everyone has a different answer to this question. We want you to start formulating yours below.

Why do you think we spend time developing your research skills in honors? What purpose do you think it might serve?

I think it is important that we develop our research skills so specifically we are able to continue learning our whole lives and not just for classes. It is important to always be learning and understanding life on deeper levels. These skills can help us with future jobs, school, or even just our own personal joy to learn in our future.

References

Booth, W. C., Colomb, G.G, & Williams, J.M. (2008). *The craft of research*. Chicago: U of Chicago P.

Plano Clark, V.L. & Cresswell, J.W. (2010). *Understanding research: A consumer's guide.* *B*oston: Merrill